

VolunteerSpot

Helping connect organizations in need of help with those seeking to give.

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ABSTRACT

Gratitude, according to Oxford Language, is “the quality of being thankful; readiness to show appreciation for and to return kindness.” One way to express gratitude is through community service, however, we found that high school and college students find it difficult to access service opportunities, especially when busy with school and other extracurricular activities. After completing eight in-depth interviews, we found students had difficulty in finding opportunities that sparked their interest, contacting organizations, as well as keeping track of their hours for organizations such as service clubs or college Greek life. To solve these problems for students, we created VolunteerSpot: an app that allows high school and college students to easily find service opportunities at the tip of their finger. VolunteerSpot utilizes an interface for volunteers, where they can filter through service opportunities by category, and an interface for organizations, who can post job opportunities. The app employs a messaging feature for communication between groups, a review widget, and can filter service opportunities by category and proximity to the user. We hope that by creating VolunteerSpot, students can use our app to give back to their community and express gratitude in an easy and interactive way.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human Centered Computing; • Interaction Design; • Interaction Design Process and Methods; • User-Centered Design;

KEYWORDS

Gratitude, volunteering, student, user-centered design, communication

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1 INTRODUCTION

Are you a college student struggling to find different means to perform or achieve service hours? If so, you are in the same boat as many other students who need to fulfill these hours for varying reasons. Many high school and college students struggle to find one cohesive resource that can provide a list of opportunities to fulfill these service hours. Someone who is a college student and part of an organization that requires a given number of service hours a semester may find it difficult to attain a certain number of service hours. Rather than relying on someone else to send out service opportunities, users should actively seek these opportunities on their own so that they are motivated to find service hours opportunities that fit in best with their schedule and interests.

As a result of what seems to be a lack of opportunities provided for service hours, students seem to be unmotivated to complete them or find different ways of achieving them. When there are opportunities posted on online platforms such as Facebook or GroupMe, the service hour opportunities are not always going to be at the most convenient time/place and may not work or fit in with a user's schedule or interests. Our solution is to provide an easily accessible and reliable platform that has a large plethora of options for students to pick and choose from. The goal would be to drive users' motivation to not only complete their service hours quickly and efficiently but to have a stronger desire and drive to actively seek service hours beyond their requirements for school and/or their organizations. However, if this issue of finding service hours is not provided, our assumption would be that the motivation for completing service hours would continue to plummet amongst students. Although the completion of service hours are more often than not a requirement, providing students with multiple opportunities through an app might be more appealing.

2 RELATED WORK

When looking at competitors, we found that there are a few other organizations that have created websites and corresponding apps in the realm of community service. We did an analysis of these other published options and compared our goals with what they provide.

2.1 Helper Helper

One design critique identified is that members have limited ability to track their own volunteer hours in the program. *Helper Helper* takes on more of a management role in terms of service: the app allows the organization's teams to delegate responsibility for members, segment time frames and schedule service hours. This was very

inspiring to us and using this idea but changing it so volunteers can track their hours will be beneficial to our application. A benefit of *Help Helper*'s design is that a segment of their website was geared toward college students— one group we believe need the most help tracking their service hours.

2.2 Give Gab

GiveGab's research shows that “people that are philanthropic are happier, but the means to connect them are limited.” This app mainly focuses on fundraising and addresses the problem that people want to give back to the community but do not have the time to do so. *GiveGab* has multiple options for donations through 24-hour giving days, philanthropy hubs, donation forms, etc. One issue with *GiveGab* is that they are not attempting to connect real people in real time— which is what our app strives to do.

2.3 JustServe

JustServe claims that all communities have service opportunities; people just don't know where to find them. *JustServe* is one of our biggest competitors because their design problem is very similar to ours. They identified the need for service and present opportunities to people who have limited hours of time, but still want to help in-person. What will differentiate our app from *JustServe* is that we will add additional ways beyond volunteering your time in which you can give back e.g. donating blood, attending a food drive, etc.

2.4 Volunteer Match

Volunteer Match allows for people to search by location or by “genre” of volunteer opportunity, like working with children, working with animals, or donating. It addresses the issue of people not knowing where to go or what to look for and gives specific opportunities, when people may only know what genre of volunteer work they want to do. There are good principles in the way you can filter opportunities by “genre”, and that they have the option to search keywords in case people already know what kind of work they are looking for. One frustrating aspect with respect to addressing the problem is that the postings are extremely outdated and include no description of the opportunity. Lastly, this app only caters to people looking to volunteer, as opposed to connecting organizations to volunteers. There are lots of hoops for organizations to jump through to post a job opportunity and it isn't very intuitive.

2.5 United Way & Get Involved

These platforms are very similar and focused on our local area: Harrisonburg, VA. They show updated volunteer events going on in the community and primarily advertise volunteer opportunities hosted by local organizations that they partner with. There are some good principles in these designs as it provides up-to-date advertisements for volunteer events coming up and we plan to use the news feed of opportunities in our design. That being said, it only shows opportunities that are co-opted with *United Way* or *Get Involved*. There is also only a small section where people can determine what kind of services they can provide, between donating, advocating, and volunteering. This makes the volunteer pool much narrower, and it also doesn't allow people to go out and find volunteer opportunities they may be interested in.

3 INITIAL USER RESEARCH

Our users are individuals who are heavily involved in community service but have been affected by a lack of information regarding existing service opportunities. We therefore chose to interview people who both enjoy, and do not enjoy participating in community service, to get a well-rounded perspective for our design to improve the service experience for everyone. We interviewed 8 college students, with 2 interviews being via Zoom, 2 via Facetime, and 4 in person. We drew up a list of interview questions and all asked each respondent about 20 questions surrounding their background, experience in service, and personal preferences and struggles, among other things. Within the college student interviews, two of the individuals we interviewed work for nonprofit organizations. One such individual worked for a local homeless shelter, and one worked for the local campus food pantry. We geared some questions for them more towards how they recruit volunteers, how volunteers help their nonprofit function, and how they interact with potential volunteers. All methods were approved by our institution's ethics review board (IRB #22-3148).

To analyze our research findings, we carefully inspected the interview responses from all 8 participants. Then we sorted quotes received from our participants into categories based on their motivations for needing help in finding service opportunities. The categories we sorted into were “wonder”, “search”, “find”, “interact”, and “share”. Based on these interviews and our analysis procedure, the most beneficial feedback we received were the features to incorporate into our app. We found that we would need a category filter, a proximity to location gauge, the option to leave reviews, and a messaging feature. From the perspective of the organizations, they wanted easy ways to communicate with their volunteers and a more streamlined way to advertise their opportunities and recruit volunteers. Based on these reviews, we made sure to incorporate job postings, a messaging feature that can be initiated by organizations, and easy ways for volunteers to come to them.

Based on these interviews and our research, we created two personas and journey maps:

4 IMPLICATIONS FOR DESIGN

After our research, we discovered that there were specific implications for design we needed to include. First, we realized that we would need to include location tracking so that our app could provide a feed of service opportunities that are nearby them. Next, we realized that along with this, we would not only need to include a server for volunteers to find jobs, but also for organizations to post jobs. This way, organizations can recruit volunteers that are near them and streamline the volunteering process. Similarly, we would need to include a messaging filter so that the organizations and volunteers can keep in contact with one another and reach out to express their gratitude for the experience they have shared with one another. Additionally, to these design requirements, we realized that we would need to include a filter for volunteers to use in their search. Not only would volunteers be able to type in a specific organization's name if they wish to volunteer, but they would be able to search service by “category”. For example, if a volunteer doesn't know where they want to volunteer, but know they are interested in working with the homeless, they can filter



Figure 1a: Primary User Persona



Figure 1b: Secondary User Persona

their searches by that category to see what organizations in their area give them the opportunity to help the homeless. Our last big design requirement that we created was a review section. Once the volunteers complete service with an organization, they can rate their experience and leave a review showing others how grateful they were for the experience and their favorite parts of completing service with the specific organization or job.

5 IDEA GENERATION

To achieve our design goals, we created many different iterations as a group to determine and narrow down our vision for VolunteerSpot. The ideas were in many different forms like sketches, storyboards, affinity diagrams, digital mockups and finally prototyping with Adobe XD. From the beginning, we knew that VolunteerSpot would be a digital resource as opposed to a physical one as we are providing our users with information that is constantly changing and updating. If we were to design a book as a resource for volunteer opportunities, it would constantly be outdated and need regular maintenance, thus that option was off the table.

6 DESIGN PROCESS

Our design process consisted of multiple steps. First, we brainstormed a list of ways that we like to practice gratitude. Once we narrowed our list down to a few ideas, we started sketching. We sketched out three ideas: one that allowed users to find community service opportunities near them, one that consisted of a gratitude

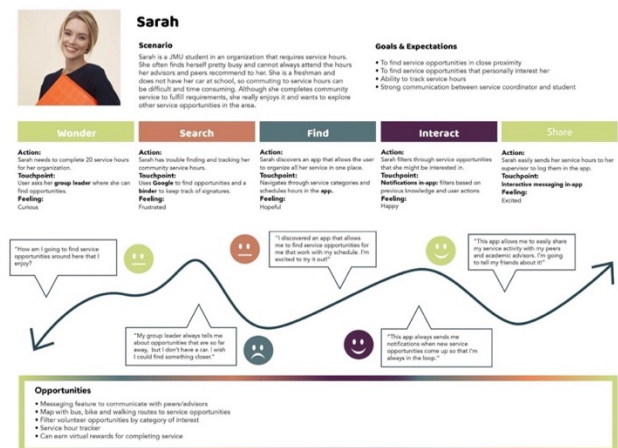


Figure 2a: Sarah User Journey Map

wheel, and a gratitude journal with a goal-setter and motivational pop-up notifications. After presenting these to our class and receiving feedback, we decided to develop our service opportunity idea. We chose this because after doing research, we found it to be the most original of the three, with not many service-oriented apps out there.

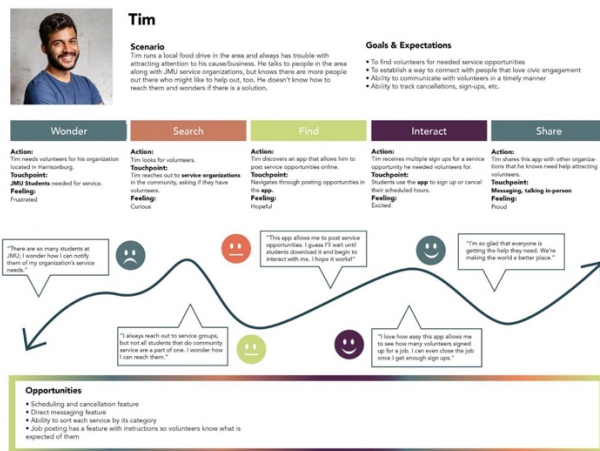


Figure 2b: Tim User Journey Map

After landing on a topic, we got to work brainstorming questions and scheduling interviews with peers. We interviewed men and women aged 16-22, all looking for service opportunities for different reasons. Our user research led us to recognize the needs of our target users, and we brainstormed six core tasks that users would complete while using the app. We created a low-fidelity prototype and tested it on three classmates. We received great feedback during our low-fidelity testing sessions and used this to develop our high-fidelity prototype by making buttons larger and organizing our navigation bar more clearly.

We started our design with a low-fidelity prototype. Our low-fidelity prototype had minimal detail to typography/color and was mainly focused on functionality. In our design, we utilized a central navigation at the bottom of the app, a 'log in' and 'create account' feature, toggles in settings to enable messaging and location, and a rating system based on 5 stars. After creating our low fidelity prototype, we were curious on how to incorporate a "type" feature to allow users to type in their own responses. We also wanted to incorporate a search feature and way for users to browse profiles or organizations in the area.

7 FINAL DESIGN

We received great feedback on our low-fidelity prototype and made multiple changes to our final design. One issue with our low-fidelity prototype was that we did not use enough feedback confirmations to assure users that they completed a task. In our high-fidelity prototype, we added feedback such as pop ups and confirmation pages to spots such as the log in page where users completed interactions as well as adding a few new toggles. We also added a back button to pages, made all buttons more accessible and clickable, and fixed bottom tabs when scrolling through categories or service opportunities.

These changes to our structure and the overall final design of our prototype serve to fulfil main categories of how to best utilize the app. The categories that we focused on improving for our

users were both from the volunteer and organization's perspective. The categories we focused on from the volunteer's perspective were "explore options based on preferences", "express gratitude", and "convenience". The way we highlighted a user's ability to explore new options based on preferences was through our filter and search tools. This way, our users can hone in on the type of service they are interested in completing. We also included a feature to ensure convenience for the users. Our prototype includes a location tracker (3a) so that users can filter search options and a home page by nearby opportunities. This makes sure that there is always something available for someone to do within a close proximity. Therefore, even if a person does not have any specific categories, they are interested in working with, they are still ensured accessible volunteer options. The next feature we focused on for volunteers was a clear way to express their gratitude by including a messaging feature (3b). This allows the volunteer to communicate with the organization they are volunteering with and thank them for the opportunities or share testimonies from their experience. They can also share their gratitude by leaving reviews on the certain jobs and stories for other potential volunteers to see what to look forward to (3c).

We also focused on categories to improve through the user experience from the organization's perspective. We mainly focused on "connectivity" and the "ability to share" through this part of our prototype. The first thing we focused on was making sure that our organizations would be able to connect to volunteers. To do this, we created features in which organizations could make job postings (4a). This allowed them to search for volunteers and create a community around their organization, along with a profile page in which they could add volunteers to their rosters of jobs. We also focused on the ability for these organizations to share their goals. Through their profile pages, they can put a description of their work and share their passion with volunteers. This ability to share is also channeled through the messaging feature (4b). Organizations can contact previous volunteers who have worked with them and let them know how grateful they have been for their service. They are also able to contact them and notify them of more postings and available jobs they may have.

8 EVALUATION AND FUTURE WORK

After including our high-fidelity modifications in our prototype, we did some final testing. We ran this testing using similar methodology as our low fidelity testing. During this testing, we downloaded Adobe XD to a cell phone to run the tests rather than them using a laptop. This was to simulate more of a similarity to an app for the user so they would feel more like they were using a real product. We then selected three participants and had the users go through 6 core tasks ranging from creating an account, to signing up for a job as a volunteer, to leaving a review. We got brilliant feedback from our users this time around. The concerns that were brought up in our low-fidelity testing were no longer on our users' minds. The criticisms we did get seemed to be more around the fact that the prototype was not a fully functional app. It took our users some getting used to when they couldn't use the keyboard fully and they were confused for a second about the auto-filling information. In terms of quantitative findings, we were able to take

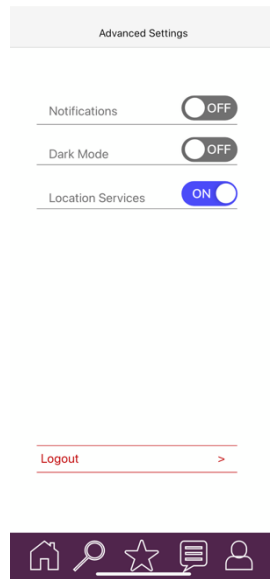


Figure 3a: Location Tracker

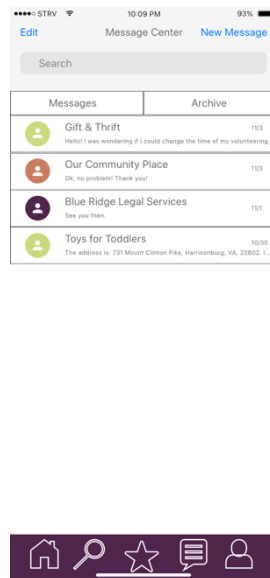


Figure 3b: Message Board

these results and feedback to create and SUS score of 86.03, which puts our high-fidelity prototype in a very successful position so move forward and work on further development. We were also told that we could better exhibit our location services in showing a map with service opportunities rather than having a list of nearby organizations. This would be a great way to refine our product in the future. Overall, based on our study, there seems to be an interest amongst students for the usage of such an app. Service hours are a requirement for many and it would be beneficial if there is an app that hosts up-to-date features that are seen on various social media platforms that our app displays.

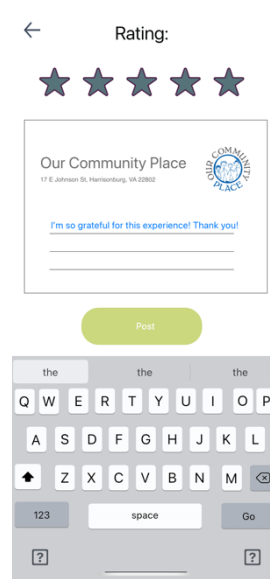


Figure 3c: Leave a Review



Figure 4a: Post a Job

9 CONCLUSION

In finalizing this semester long project, we have learned that feedback, testability, and collaboration are the most important aspects in the process of designing an application. In turn, incorporating modern, up-to-date features and ideas are crucial in maintaining interest in an application. Our app overall seemed that it would serve a purpose for High School, college, and any students or others who need service hours. Our goal of creating a simple design layout that is straightforward to users in search of service hours was achieved by the end. Connecting the notion of gratitude to

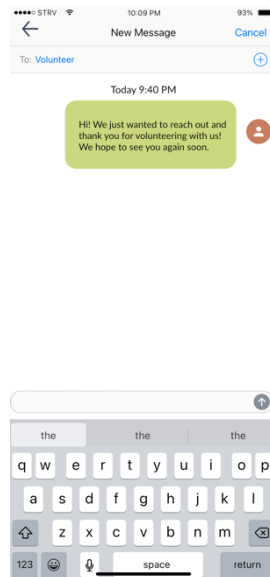


Figure 4b: Send a Message

service was made possible through specific features we added to our design layout, specifically in the messaging feature. Overall, we feel that we checked off our list of tasks to complete in relation to our app and how it could be made the most easily laid out for users.

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